

COMMUNICATION

Communication is the transfer of information from one person to another. The information could be facts, ideas, opinions, orders, emotions etc.

Little (1983) viewed communication as the process by which information is passed between individuals or organisations by means of previously agreed symbols.

Fisher (1981) asserts that communication is the process by which verbal and nonverbal symbols are exchanged between two (2) or more persons.

Udall and Udall (1979) defines communication as a process by which a person shares and imparts information to another person or groups that clearly understand each other.

Written Communication

This is the type of communication that is written. It does not necessarily require the physical presence of the sender. All that is required is the putting down or writing of one's ideas in a clear and logical manner in the language the receiver understands. It comes in the form of letters, memos, reports, minutes of a meeting, articles, press releases, advertisements, invitations, news bulletins etc.

Written communication creates room for permanent written record to be kept and evidence of dispatch and receipts of messages are available. It also creates opportunity for the analysis and evaluation of messages. Moreover, it has the advantage of disseminating information to dispersed audience.

Like the oral communication, written communication also has its disadvantages;

1. It does not permit immediate clarification.
2. It takes time to produce and it can be very expensive.
3. Feedback is not instantaneous.
4. It does not create room for exchange of opinions, views or attitudes except over a period of time.
5. Communication tends to be distant and more informal.
6. Problem of interpretation may occur and once it is dispatched, it may be difficult to modify.

PURPOSE OF COMMUNICATION

1. To persuade
2. Dissemination of information

3. Establishing relationship
4. Expressing of feelings
5. Convey orders
6. Education.

LETTER WRITING

A letter can be defined as a written communication that is hand written, typed or printed for an individual or an organisation. It can be classified into formal, semi-formal and informal letter.

PRINCIPLES OF LETTER WRITING

1. Be natural and simple: be natural and simple through spontaneous out pouring of thoughts and ideas as they naturally occur to the writer. Stiff and laboured conversation usually bore the readers.
2. The writer should never attempt to convey an impression that he is other than what he is. It would be silly as well as vain for a street labourer with a limited education to try and emulate a college professor. Always write base on your level of education and exposure.
3. Consider who your audience are: if your letter is for the president or religious leaders, you should have different term from the ones you write to your friends.
4. Focus and specificity: in official correspondence the language should be strictly official. Avoid the use of ambiguous words but rather use clear, precise and concise expressions that is straight to the point and above all honest.
5. Writing completely: good business letter should have all the relevant facts and complete information so that there are no unnecessary queries.
6. Courtesy and consideration: apart from using courtesy words like thank you or please, reply the letter immediately even if no action has taken place in order to establish confidence and trust,
7. Avoid jugglery or jumbling words: it is important that the language of the letter should not be like essay or article from literary point of view. It should be written in short sentences with simple words.
8. Avoid the use of commercial words/ phrases/ abbreviations: the use these should be avoided as they have become obsolete and out of practice. Eg
 - i. I beg to inform you
 - ii. For your information

- iii. Please don't hesitate to call

Where they can't be substituted their use should be minimized or avoided in the letters.

- 9. Effectiveness: good business letter should be concise, precise, relevant, concrete and consistent so that it is easily understood by the reader and its content should be fully followed. The letter should be arranged in the relevant way so that the important facts should be given prime importance.
- 10. Planning the letter: the writer of the letter should have good thinking power and should plan out its contents before writing the letter. Planning helps in assorting all relevant facts, figures, and places so that the letter becomes more useful and result oriented.

The following steps are to be considered when planning a letter:

- i. Collecting facts or information
- ii. Selecting right or accurate style / approach
- iii. Arranging facts, figures and plates.

BUSINESS LETTERS

Formal letter also called business or official letters are written to discuss issues with organizations, individuals, government or co-operate bodies. In other words, they are written to persons, authority or officers who occupy certain positions in the offices.

COMPONENTS / PARTS OF A BUSINESS LETTER

- i. Writers Address: This refers to the address of the person that is writing the letter. It appears at top right of the letter. It consist of street/department, city, box number, town etc. Eg

The Federal Polytechnic, Mubi,
P.M.B 35,
Mubi,
Adamawa State.

- ii. The receivers address (Addressee's address): This is the address of the person to whom the letter in addressed. It contains the official status / Rank, organization name etc. It is written on the right hand side of the paper directly below the date. e.g.

The Registrar,
Federal Polytechnic, Mubi,
Mubi.

- iii. The date: It indicates the day, month and year the letter was written and it comes immediately below the writer's address.eg **1st October, 2022.**

- iv. **The Salutation:** It refers to the complimentary greeting with which the writer opens the letter. The formal greeting begins at the left hand margin below the inside address. e.g.: Dear Sir, Dear Madam, Or Sir, Madam,
- v. **The Subject/Title:** The subject tells what the letter is about and is usually positioned between the salutation and the body e.g. ***Application for the Post of a Sales Man.***
- vi. **The Body:** The body contains the message. It begins below the title/subject. The body of a business letter in particular has its characteristics parts; reference, information, purpose and conclusion. The message is organized in paragraphs and conveyed to the receiver.
- vii. **The Complimentary close:** This is the formal goodbye which is usually placed below the last line of the body e.g. ***Yours faithfully,***
- viii. **Signature.** This refers to the inscription of the writer below the subscription usually written in longhand.
- ix. **Name in full:** The name of the writer is written in full below the signature

TYPES OF OFFICIAL LETTERS /BUSINESS LETTERS

- Application letters (for employment)
- Letter of Appreciation
- Letter of Complaint
- Letter of termination (of appointment)
- Letter of Promotion
- Letter of Congratulation
- Letter of Condolence
- Letter of Query
- Letter of Enquiring
- Letter of Appointment
- Letter of Recommendation
- Letter of order, remittance, permission etc

LETTER OF APPLICATION

A letter of application is an official letter, usually written by someone seeking for a job in an organization. Such a letter should conform to all the basic features of official letter writing.

A good letter of application must contain the following:

- a. State the nature of the job you are seeking and why you are applying to the company or organization.
- b. State briefly how the knowledge of the vacancy was obtained (ie advertised or oral information).
- c. The position being applied for
- d. Personal data.
- e. State where you can be reached and hope that you will be invited for an interview.

FORMAT OF AN APPLICATION LETTER

Federal Polytechnic,
P.M.B. 35,
Mubi.
Adamawa State.
20th, September, 2015.

The Registrar,
Federal Polytechnic, Mubi,
Mubi.
Dear Sir,

Application for a Position of Senior a Lecturer in English Language

Your advertisement of 21st August, 2015, in the daily sketch refers. I would like to apply for a position as a senior lecturer in English Language with your department of English studies.

I am a holder of B.Ed English (Second Class Upper Division) and M.A English – stylistics of the University of Ibadan.

Attached are the details of my qualification for a senior lecturer position in your institution.

I would be most grateful if my application is given a kind consideration.

Yours faithfully,

Signature
Abdul Usman.

APPLICATION BY CURRICULUM VITEA (CV)

CV is a short written summary of a person's career, qualifications and education. It can be referred to as the brief account of a person's education, qualifications and previous occupation, typically sent with a job application.

- A. Provide in precise form all information required in the advertisement e.g.
 - 1. Personal Details
 - i. Full name
 - ii. Postal address and permanent home address
 - iii. Telephone number
 - iv. Date of birth
 - v. Sex
 - vi. Nationality
 - vii. Marital status
 - 2. Qualifications i.e. primary school, secondary school, diploma, degree, etc. the name of institutions and dates when the certificate were obtained should be stated.
 - 3. Employment History: mention the name employer, dates, job title, duties involved and places; include volunteer work as well as paid work.
 - 4. Honours and Awards: list of all distinctions whether academic or non-academic.
 - 5. Publications i.e. journals, textbooks, festschrift etc.
 - 6. Co-curricular activities: any activity that may be useful to the employer e.g. sports, creativity etc.
 - 7. Reference: list of persons that can be contacted with regards to the applicant details. Such persons can be the applicant's former head of department, supervisor, spiritual father, previous boss etc.
- B. Remember to attach the CV to a covering letter containing information that can sell your letter.

PROTEST LETTER

Such letters usually arise from anger resulting from deprivation of one's right. The following should be considered when writing a protest letter:

- 1. After writing put it aside for at least one night and read it the following day to avoid regret.
- 2. Be able to support anything that you write
- 3. The details must be accurate
- 4. The details must be relevant.

LETTER OF RECOMMENDATION

It is usually written in support of an applicant's application for a job or admission; basically dealing with a testimony of the applicant in terms of character, qualification and experience.

Guidelines

1. For lower cadre of employment, you stress character only
2. For higher cadre, qualification, experience character and wealth come to play
3. For admission into higher institution, you stress character, qualification and experience
4. The letter must be direct courteous, clear and convincing
5. The letter should contain statement of authority
6. It should contain appearance and special ability of the applicant
7. Grade the beneficiary to be either high, very high or excellent.

Letter of recommendation are of two (2) types that is:

1. Solicited: you have been requested to write by the prospective employer or institution.
2. Unsolicited: it is called testimonial because the address is not known. It bears the caption **[TO WHOM IT MAY CONCERN]**. In this type of letter there is no addressee's address, no complimentary close and fixed subject line.

LETTER OF QUERY

Query letter is an official letter that does not require salutation and complimentary close. These kind of letters are usually written to any employee who has erred or committed offence in carrying out his responsibilities. It is basically intended to correct, maintain discipline and standard in office.

Guidelines

1. The salutation should carry the employees name
2. Clearly and meticulously list the problem and the reason for issuing the letter
3. Explain the action that is required to correct the issue
4. Advise what disciplinary action will follow
5. Provide time frame in which the employee has to respond i.e. twenty four (24) hours, forty eight (48) hour etc.
6. Close your letter on a positive note

REPLY TO QUERY LETTERS

A reply to letter of complaint or query is done to explain why something unexpected or unusual has happened. A writer of such letter is expected to:

1. Control his / her emotions
2. He or she should take pains and answer the query point by point in a logical and sequential manner
3. The officer who wrote the query should not be held in contempt
4. His personality should not be insulted
5. The content and tone should be polite.

CONDOLENCE LETTER

A condolence letter is a piece of written communication expressing sympathy. It is a letter written to provide great source of comfort to someone grieving the loss of a loved one. This letter is a simple gesture that lets someone know they are in your thoughts.

Guidelines

1. Try and write your condolence letter promptly at least two (2) weeks following the loss
2. Acknowledge the loss by referring to the deceased by name
3. Express your sympathy
4. Note a special quality of the deceased in the letter
5. Include your favourite memory of the deceased
6. Offer to help the family
7. End with a thoughtful hope “always with you in prayer”, “I will always be here to support you”

CONGRATULATORY LETTER

A congratulatory letter is a written communication used in both personal and business situations. The primary purpose of such piece of writing is to formally felicitate with a person / individual or an organisation for an outstanding achievement.

Guidelines

1. Try and send the letter within twenty fours (24) hours if possible
2. Mention the persons or organisations role / accomplishment

3. Do not get too personal
4. Keep it succinct and end with an appropriate closing.

MEMORANDUM

Memo is a written communication from one person to another or a group of people within the same organization.

Purpose of a Memo

- i. To give information concerning decisions already taken;
- ii. To make request for action and information;
- iii. To provide information of any kind;

The subject matter of a memo may be confidential. If this is so, the memo may be enclosed within an envelope. Depending on the procedure adopted within the organization, the memo may be signed, initiated or simply left unsigned.

Similarities between a Memo and a Business Letter

1. Both are written communication
2. They both have dates
3. Both carry the senders name
4. Both have titles / subjects etc.

Differences between a Memo and a Business Letter

1. Memo is strictly an internal communication while business letter is not.
2. Memo takes a printed pad (letter head paper) while business letter has two addresses
3. Memo carries only one single subject.
4. Business letter has salutation
5. Memo has **TO** and **FROM** with a **REFERENCE NUMBER**
6. Memo may be signed or left unsigned while business letter must be signed etc.

PROJECT REPORT

Before understanding the concept of a project report, it will be wise to know what a report is. A report refers to an account of something witnessed or examined, work carried out of investigation or observation with recommendation if required.

Purpose of a Report

1. Information
2. To report findings
3. Put forward ideas
4. Recommend a course of action
5. Record an event or issue for future reference
6. Find out the quality of work done prior to the investigation ~
7. To establish a fact or correct error

The project report falls within the category of writing tasks classified as technical writing.

Nwogu (1998) defines project report as the final product of work based on investigation, experience, observation, research, experimentation etc. it contains objective and factual information which makes it a serious document. For the work to be complete there is a section that is known as the preliminary section which contains the following:

- i. **Title Page:** this page indicates what a particular report is. It shows all the identities that would facilitate the easy access and identification of a report giving such information as :
 - a. Subject of the report
 - b. The writer
 - c. The person or the appropriate authority that will utilize the report
 - d. Date
- ii. **Table of Content:** this shows the structure of a report in a sketchy form. It brings headings and sub-headings together, indicating the pages on which each heading or sub-heading would be found. It aids understanding of the content and also helps to locate particular headings or sub-headings needed at a particular time without necessarily reading through the whole report.

- iii. Acknowledgements: the writer of a report use this part to express gratitude to all whose co-operations and help contributed to the success of the investigation. This is done by mentioning names.
- iv. Abstract: it is a very short summary of the report. The abstract summarizes the purpose of the report, states the nature of its conclusions and recommendations.

Every project report begins with a chapter that introduces the work (project) termed the introduction. This chapter tells the reader what the project is all about. It also provides the reader with the necessary background details he requires to understand the problems investigated in the study. The chapter is referred to as chapter one (1). The chapter has the following sub-sections:

1.1 Background of the Study: this sub-section is obligatory in the introduction chapter. It provides information on the circumstances surrounding the work, that is the context and the situation that led to the study. The background of the study is essential because it provides a basis for discussion and helps the researcher put the topic in proper perspective by defining clearly the area where the problem can be situated. It presents the reader with information on established knowledge in the area, usually supported with authoritative sources.

1.2 Statement of the Problem: in this section an attempt is made to define the problem that is being researched on. The problem must be clearly formulated in words. The statement of the problem is the statement that indicates the main thrust or theme of the study. Its aim is to establish or state that a gap exists that needs to be filled. It is usually written in a prose form.

1.3 Aim and Objectives: this is the purpose of the study. This sub-section lets the reader understand what the research is all about. It is usually brief, involving the breaking down of the research problem into ideas to be focused upon in the study. It normally begins with a preamble or opening statement which restates the research theme, followed by a statement indicating the purpose of the study (aims) and objectives.

1.4 Significance of the Study: this sub-section describes the value of the research or its importance. That is the contribution of the study to knowledge. The significance of the study also entails the beneficiaries' i.e. individuals, students, organizations, communities etc. the section should be guided by the research questions and hypothesis and their possible solutions.

1.5 Research Questions: these are questions that act as a guide to the researcher in collecting relevant data for his research. It has a close relationship with the aim and objectives of the study because they constitute a reformation of purpose of the study into set of operational questions. The

questions must be specific and properly focused. Each question should focus on one objective. E.g.

- i. The effects of temperature variation on the insulation resistance of computer hardware (objective)
- ii. What effects do temperature variations have on the resistance of computer hardware?

1.6 Hypothesis: this is a tentative assumption made in order to draw out and test the logical or empirical consequences of a situation regarding some population under study. The assumption may or may not be true. A hypothesis needs to be stated clearly and unambiguously in the form of a declarative sentence not as a question. E.g.

- i. Institutional rules and regulations have no significant influence on the maintenance of discipline in a computer school. (Null type)
- ii. Institutional rules and regulations have an influence on the maintenance of discipline in a computer school. (Alternate)

L.7 Scope and Limitations: the scope refers to the area the study covers in terms of the field of study. It gives an explanation on the subject and defines the exact areas to be covered by writer while limitations refers to the statement(s) indicating those factors which have limited the scope of the study and the extent to which the results obtained can be generalizable. It is necessary to state these boundary conditions in the report so that the reader might know where to peg his expectations.

Reviewing Related Literature (chapter 2)

The second chapter in a research project work is the review of related literature. It is a very important chapter because it provides a thorough assessment of work that has been done in the field which is related to the study being reported upon. The aim of the chapter is to provide an objective assessment of related studies, to indicate their relevance or otherwise to the present study and to highlight their strength and weaknesses.

Strategies and skills for discussing related literature:

- i. Citation skills: this is a reference to previous research or the works of others. The act of citing involves:
 - a. Reference to personal names (surname)
 - b. Reference to date of publication

- c. Use of appropriate tense form. E.g. Jones (1970) reported that Citations can be information prominence or author prominence.
- ii. Paraphrasing: this is the act of presenting in your own words what someone else has said or done on the subject of your research with a view to analyzing them and indicating how acceptable or unacceptable, related or unrelated they are to your topic. Paraphrasing means reading and understanding a piece of any length and rewriting it in your own words and style. It is done with aim of retaining all the ideas in the source material. For effective paraphrasing adhere to the following:
 - a. Change the grammatical structure of sentences.
 - b. Change the vocabulary in the source material as much as possible using synonyms, expressions or simple phrases.
 - c. Keep the length of the paraphrased material as much as possible to that of the source material.
 - d. Write using your own style not the style of the original material.
- iii. Quotation: this is the act of quoting verbatim. Make sure your quotation is absolutely correct. When using quotations page number is attached to the name and year. E.g. Jones (1980)p 115

Methodology (chapter 3)

This chapter provides an account of the steps followed in conducting the research, describes the materials used and discusses procedures adopted in analyzing data. The chapter enables the reader knows the extent to which the results obtained in the study are consistent with the methods used. It also provides a useful guide to researchers who may be interested in extending or replicating the study.

Order of presenting information in the chapter

3.1 Introduction: this states what the chapter is all about. It also contains the main elements of information that are discussed in the chapter and the order in which they are presented.

3.2 Research Design: this section presents an overview of the study by indicating the research strategy adopted in ensuring that the study provides answers to fundamental questions raised in the research.

3.3 Sampling Techniques: this is the method of ensuring that the subjects collected for the study are representatives of the group from which they are collected. I.e. random, stratified, cluster, purposive etc.

3.4 Method of Data Collection: this section describes the methods used in gathering information or data for the study.

3.5 Method of Data Analysis: this refers to how the data will be analyzed. I.e. statistical, corpus etc.

Results and Discussion (chapter 4)

This chapter is the heart of the report. It is the aspect of the project report in which the findings are presented with brief comments on them. The content of the findings is the list of all important discoveries made in the procedures.

The findings are not the writer's opinion and should not represent the biases of the writer. The findings are facts contained in the materials of information consulted. The information chapter consists of tables, graphs, charts and other figures. The text should not duplicate information in the tables or figures but should only highlight significant aspects of the findings.

Summary, Conclusion and Recommendations (chapter 5)

This chapter is essentially concerned with summarizing the results obtained, drawing conclusion based on the findings, stating the implications of the research findings and making recommendations.

Conclusion: this chapter includes all substantial inferences arrived by the writer(s) made possible by the thorough examination of the facts presented in the findings of the report.

Conclusions are not findings; rather they are logical opinions of the writer enhanced by the findings.

Recommendations: recommendations are made in a report only in response to the stipulations of the terms of reference.

Recommendations include the solutions and advice given by the writer as probable means of solving the problems raised in the discoveries and conclusions.

References: these are same with footnotes. The modern style has a practice of arranging all footnotes at the end of the entire work. It is a previously published written work thus indicating a source. E.g.

Nwogu, K. N. (1988). *Technical Report Writing: A Practical Guide to Writing-up Research in Science, Medicine, Engineering and Technology*. Yola: Paraclete Publishers.

Onozulike, U. (2007). The Birth of Nollywood. *The Journal of Indiana University Press. Black Camera*, 22(1), 25-26. The former is for books while the latter is meant for journals only.

Appendixes: the charts, photographs, maps and other related information that are useful in the interpretation of the report are called appendixes. They are attached to the report they relate to at the end.